

Chrome Extensions Development

It's Fun and Addictive



The Google Chrome browser burst upon the scene a little over a year ago. Chromium is the open source project that Google Chrome is based on. Beta versions of Google Chrome for Linux and Mac were released in December 2009, along with extensions.

Extensions are small additions of features for the browser to improve its usability. Adding these is simpler than modifying the browser's source code. The vibrant Firefox extension community is one aspect that sets it apart from Chrome, so it will be interesting to see how Chrome's extension community develops.

Mouse Stroke is an extension for Google Chrome that lets you use mouse gestures to do things quickly within a browser—such as opening and closing tabs, or moving back and forth between pages.

Here is a Q-and-A session with Quan Gan, author of the Mouse Stroke, where he shares his experiences with Chrome.

Q Tell us about yourself.

I'm a software engineer living in Beijing, China. I'm 28 years old. Although I'm not as involved with open source development as many others around, I do have some projects—mostly tiny ones—hosted at both SourceForge and Google Code.

Q How did you get interested in Google Chrome and its extensions?

I started to use Chromium because Firefox is slow on my Debian box. I found Chromium breezing fast, and started using it under Windows too. I started to make extensions for Chromium because I wanted to port my GreaseMonkey script, a telnet emulator, to Chromium so that I could secretly browse a telnet BBS at work :)

I didn't really get interested in developing mouse gesture extensions at the beginning. I was happy with Strokelt under Windows and Easystroke under X. However, my laptop at the office is strictly monitored by my administrator—I'm not allowed to install any software—so I decided to develop a mouse gesture extension.

It's called Mouse Stroke. I posted the first version at chromeextensions.org and said to myself: "That's it... the final version!" But it turned out that people hated it :)

A bug in the first version killed many websites, including Gmail. So I had to pick up the source and make another version, then another version. At least it doesn't kill Gmail anymore :)

Ironically, I started to use Chromium because it's fast on Linux, but my extension still doesn't work on the Linux version of Chromium. That's because Linux Chromium handles mouse events differently from the Windows version, which makes it impossible for the developers to control the context menu. This also applies to the Mac